

That could be wishful thinking. The party has even failed to project a chief ministerial candidate. Even its claim that the electorate had voted for the alliance and not an individual flies in the face of statistics. The BJP was virtually zero in Orissa till it joined hands with the BJD. In the 1991 and 1996 Lok Sabha polls, it drew a blank. One of the reasons for the BJD dumping the BJP was a survey that Pyari Mohan Mohapatra, a retired bureaucrat and Naveen's one-man think-tank commissioned. It showed that 79 per cent of the people had voted for the alliance in the name of "Naveen babu" and only 21 per cent for the BJP.

In the face of these handicaps and signs of anti-incumbency starting to impact the BJD, it is the Congress that seems poised to gain. Congress chief Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi have been making frequent forays into rural Orissa, charming the voters and creating a significant stir. The party, which had secured 34.8 per cent votes and 38 assembly seats in 2000 and 40.43 per cent votes but only two Lok Sabha seats in 2004, is upbeat and may well ride out the general lack of awareness about

SINGH DEO (CENTRE) MAY LACK CHARISMA BUT HAS CREDIBILITY (BELOW) WHILE THE BJP GOES STARRY-EYED WITH HEMA MALINI



Congress candidates in assembly constituencies. The high command has grounded the 82-year-old J.B. Patnaik, three-time chief minister, and the man who was the favourite target of Naveen and BJP leaders for his corrupt image, and instead, brought in the non-controversial K.P. Singh Deo as pcc chief.

With the BJD and BJP pitted against each other in all constituencies, the Congress can hope to benefit and could easily increase its 2004 tally to emerge as the single-largest party. Advani during his campaign not only asked the voters to "isolate" Naveen in this election but told them "if not the BJP then anybody else". That "anybody else" means the Congress. Party spokesperson Kailash Acharya says, "The wind is blowing in favour of the Congress." The party has allotted 25 per cent tickets to the youth, in keeping with Rahul Gandhi's strategy. New faces could prove an effective weapon in a state where traditional leaders have consistently failed to perform or acquired a bad image.

For Naveen, this is his sternest test. Apart from the strident attacks by the BJP, mostly aimed at the Hindu vote, there are other issues which he will find hard to contend with. Sonia has been harping on the fact that the BJD-BJP government could not utilise Central funds and it was the UPA which set up institutions like IIT and an AIIMS branch. Besides, a CAG exposé about misappropriation of Rs 1,400 crore of welfare funds and non-utilisation of mid-day meal funds provided by the Centre has also embarrassed Naveen. Despite his claims of development, the facts are not on his side. In the latest estimates by the Planning Commission, the state had the highest incidence of poverty, with 39.9 per cent of its population now living below the poverty line, ahead of Bihar's 32.5 per cent. Despite the survey, lacking an influential ally will hurt Naveen. The BJP too will suffer from the lack of his presence. The Congress, meanwhile, is waiting to pick up the pieces and right now, it's the only party that's poised to improve on its past record. ■